Evaluative Claims: A "Meaningful" Internal Critique of Ogden and Richards

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Few phrases carry more weight in ordinary speech, or less content, than "a meaningful life." We say it at funerals, in commencement speeches, and in moments of reflection, and we say it as though it named something a life could possess or lack. This paper argues that it names nothing. Drawing on C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards' *The Meaning of Meaning*, chiefly their survey of the senses of "meaning" in Chapter IX and their analysis of the ethical "good" in Chapter VI, I argue that the predicate "meaningful," applied to a life, makes no difference to what a sentence refers to; it expresses an attitude toward a life rather than stating a fact about it. The more interesting claim is that Ogden and Richards possessed every tool needed to reach this conclusion themselves. Having identified an emotive use of "meaning" under their definition XI and having already shown that the ethical "good" "stands for nothing whatever,"[1] they nonetheless classified "the Meaning of Life" as a symbolic phrase, one concerning purpose or significance. A simple test shows this to be a misclassification: read as purpose or significance, the phrase either invents a referent or loses the evaluation that speakers intend, and only the emotive reading, the one later developed by A. J. Ayer, accounts for how it is actually used. The conclusion is narrow. It is not that lives lack value, but that "meaningful" is a convenient device of language, and, as Ogden and Richards themselves warn, a device becomes an error once we suppose it to be "an addition to our knowledge."[2] To show this, this paper first sets out Ogden and Richards' account of meaning and the senses of the word they reject, then their classification of "the meaning of life," then tests that classification against their own definitions VII, VIII, and XI, and finally answer four anticipated objections.

[1] C. K. Ogden and I. A. Richards, *The Meaning of Meaning: A Study of the Influence of Language upon Thought and of the Science of Symbolism*, 8th ed. (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, n.d.; first published 1923), 125.

[2] Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 188.

To ground this inquiry in concrete philosophical thought, we ought to begin with Ogden and Richards' idea of "word magic" or, as Ogden and Richards put it,

> *"The root of the trouble will be traced to the superstition that words are in some way parts of things or always imply things corresponding to them, historical instances of this still potent instinctive belief being given from many sources."*[3]

This inquiry can perhaps seem eccentric or unorthodox, but in modern linguistic philosophy, it is not. It is easy to see how, in reality, words have no intrinsic meaning; they simply have subjective meaning that we have socially agreed upon. For example, take the word "boat": well, on its own, it means nothing. Suppose someone shouted the ancient Sanskrit word for boat in a park you were walking by: to you, it would fundamentally mean nothing. But to someone who speaks ancient Sanskrit, it just means a vessel that can transport individuals, goods, or substances across bodies of water. This means that while words have no magical meaning in and of themselves, in social context they can have a great degree of importance. However, this does give rise to some issues as to how we can agree upon the meaning of words. On that issue, Ogden and Richards say the following:

> *"[I]n most matters the possible treachery of words can only be controlled through definitions . . . provided that we do not suppose symbols to have 'meaning' on their own account, and so people the world with fictitious entities."*[4]

Ogden and Richards state that this linguistic confusion prevention framework is conditional on individuals not attaching meaning to specific words, which they refer to as symbols, and if individuals do fall prey to that, then we will have the issue of fictitious entities, or made-up meanings for words that have no intrinsic value to support such a proposition. This will go on to support their idea of the "Meaning Triangle," which is also commonly referred to as the "Semantic Triangle".[5] The triangle theory holds that a symbol (word) is meaningless. For example, the symbol dog, referencing the word dog, is of no meaning. However, this symbol triggers a thought or reference to an idea, and then to an actual dog (referent). Now, upon a first read, a reader may think that the referent is what the authors intend to have the meaning, while some other readers may think the thought is the most meaningful of the relational aspects of the triangle; however, Ogden and Richards hold that the meaning is the referent, reached only indirectly through the thought; it is the relationship between the symbol, idea, and referent that makes meaning possible.

This is something humans often fall prey to, as it is commonplace to say phrases such as

[3]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 14–15.

[4]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 206.

[5]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 10–12.

"that rock has weight" or "that cat has black fur"; however, these are fundamentally different empirical claims to metaphysical claims such as "that life has meaning". Weight is a realized, empirical, testable property. You can pick up the rock, put it on a scale and weigh it; maybe it's twenty pounds, roughly one and a half stone, nine kilograms: it has a referent, or a property grounding its meaning in reality. "Meaningful" is different: it is immaterial; you cannot weigh it; it has no referent, all of which leads people to try, subjectively, to parse out meaning in different individuals' lives. Does meaning mean importance, power, pedigree, influence? Ogden and Richards include sixteen different (in reality, they list twenty-three) definitions of meaning.[6] While unnecessary to list all of them, all of these definitions fit into one of three categories: metaphysical meaning, borrowed meaning, and relational meaning. Metaphysical meaning is essentially what we've already discussed and Ogden and Richards do not deal with it further in this work. However, borrowed meaning is dealt with extensively, with Ogden and Richards' writing,

> *"No convenient symbolic device is objectionable so long as we know that it is a device and do not suppose it to be an addition to our knowledge. To let a convenience turn into an argument, and decide for us as to the nature of the universe in the fashion of Dr Santayana's 'Essences' is a gratuitous tactic."*[7]

This is, in essence, Ogden and Richards' case against Group B: not against these ways of speaking as linguistic devices, but against mistaking them for knowledge. The difficulty faced within Group B is that a device used long enough for linguistic convenience stops appearing as a device but rather looks temptingly like the underlying truth behind it. Grammar obliges us to speak of "redness" as though it existed apart from red things. Yet, in Ogden and Richards' view, the sole entities in the real world are propertied things which are only symbolically distinguishable into properties and things.[8] The distinction is real in our symbols and essentially nowhere else. To forget this is to make a linguistic tool into a logical proposition. Ogden and Richards do not wish to abolish any of these idioms. They simply caution against supposing that what language requires us to say is in harmony with the underlying logical assumptions of language.

This brings the discussion to Group C, and more importantly Ogden and Richards' support of Group C, specifically their definition XIII (symbols and their suggestions or associations), which directly supports their Semantic Triangle theory. The best single passage in the work

[6]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 186–87. The count of twenty-three is the author's, treating VII(a–b), XIII(a–d), the unnumbered "User of a Symbol" entry, and XVI(a–c) as separate definitions.

[7]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 188–89.

[8]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 188.

that summarizes the thesis of Ogden and Richards is,

> *"All thinking, all reference, it was maintained, is adaptation due to psychological contexts which link together elements in external contexts. . . . According to this the meaning of A is that to which the mental process interpreting A is adapted. This is the most important sense in which words have meaning."*[9]

In support of their symbolic framework, Ogden and Richards hold that the most important sense in which a word "means" something is psychological. The meaning of a word is that to which the mental process interpreting it is adapted, where the adaptation is the product of the interpreter's past experience. Recurring clusters of events form corresponding psychological contexts, so that when part of the cluster recurs, the mind responds. Meaning is therefore, in Ogden and Richards' view, neither a property of the word nor something the mind imposes upon it. It is the thing a mind is directed toward when it encounters the word. That is why the same word can mean different things to different people, and why the meaning of words is, at least in principle, a question for psychology and semantics rather than metaphysics.

However, Ogden and Richards do falter at one specific point, and it is arguably one of the more important applications of meaning in philosophical thought. The authors first observe that when the universe is regarded as showing evidence of design, "meaning" slides into "purpose," so that the meaning of anything becomes its purpose as conceived by the speaker acting as "interpreter of the divine plan." They then turn to the phrase directly:

> *"Such a phrase as the Meaning of Life (cf., for example, Professor Munsterberg's treatment above) usually implies such a view, but there is sometimes another possible interpretation when Meaning is equated with 'Significance' (VIII). Here the notion of purpose is not always implied, and the meaning of anything is said to have been grasped when it has been understood as related to other things or as having its place in some system as a whole."*[10]

Dense as the passage is, its classification is clear. The phrase "the meaning of life," and by extension a claim such as "his life was meaningful," usually falls under definition VII, purpose, and occasionally under definition VIII, significance. On either reading the phrase is treated as symbolic. It refers to something, whether the ends a life serves or the wider system in which it has its place, and so it can in principle be true or false. The authors are, in other words, charitable to the phrase. That charity is difficult to reconcile with their treatment of "good" in Chapter VI:

> *"This peculiar ethical use of 'good' is, we suggest, a purely emotive use. When so used the word stands for nothing whatever, and has no symbolic function.*

[9]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 200.

[10]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 196.

> *Thus, when we so use it in the sentence, 'This is good,' we merely refer to this, and the addition of 'is good' makes no difference whatever to our reference. . . . [I]t serves only as an emotive sign expressing our attitude to this, and perhaps evoking similar attitudes in other persons."*[11]

The claim here is precise. The ethical "good" is not false, nor is it worthless. It simply makes "no difference whatever to our reference." To say "this is good" is to point at this and to express an attitude toward it, nothing more. The target of the passage is G.E. Moore, whose *Principia Ethica* holds that "good" names a unique, unanalyzable property.[12] Ogden and Richards answer that the word names nothing at all, a conclusion A.J. Ayer would later make the basis of his emotivist ethics.[13]

The difficulty is that Ogden and Richards possessed every tool needed to treat "meaningful" in the same way as they treated "good", and in fact they did so elsewhere. Under definition XI they observe of "meaning" itself:

> *"The word is often purely emotive (cf. 'Good' p. 125), and on these occasions, if the writer is what is known as a stylist, will have no substitute nor will a sensible reader attempt a symbolic definition."*[14]

The emotive use of "meaning" is therefore one they named, and they tied it explicitly to their analysis of "good." Their error lies not in contradiction but in classification: having identified the emotive sense, they assigned the emotive phrase "the meaning of life" to the definitions of purpose and significance. Calling a life meaningful is the clearest case of the very use their definition XI describes, and it ought to be filed there. This mistake can be explored with a simple test.

In this testing section, it will be shown that if we accept Ogden and Richards' own semantic system, treating "the meaning of life" as symbolic either creates the exact linguistic errors they sought to destroy or fails to capture what the speaker means; classifying it as emotive is the only way to keep their system consistent with its own treatment of "good." Firstly, we can test a claim regarding a meaningful life under definition VII (Purpose) offered by Ogden and Richards. Suppose someone claimed "Person X lived a meaningful life," and by meaningful life, when pressed, they meant that person X's life had been lived in conjunction with a predetermined purpose. This is especially present in religious contexts, as religious individuals often mean, in asserting meaningful lives, that the life was lived in harmony with divine principles. However, if we take this premise to be true, then we have violated precisely

[11]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 125.

[12]G. E. Moore, *Principia Ethica* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1903), chap. 1.

[13]A. J. Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic* (London: Victor Gollancz, 1936), chap. 6.

[14]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 199.

what Ogden and Richards set out to do in the first place: erase "word magic" and not "people the world with fictitious entities."[15] Outside of a religious framework, the speaker may instead mean purpose in Ogden and Richards' own sense, "an event intended":[16] person X's own goals, such as raising three children and putting each of them through school. These goals are real, empirical events. However, once we specify the goal, the claim reduces to "Person X raised three children and put each of them through school," and the term "meaningful" becomes entirely redundant. The example is deliberately stated without evaluative terms: once the goal is put as a plain fact, nothing remains for "meaningful" to add except the speaker's approval, which is the emotive reading tested below. Either way, definition VII fails: in the religious case it peoples the world with fictitious entities, and in the secular case the word is simply redundant.

Secondly, take the same example, "Person X lived a meaningful life," but now test it under definition VIII (significance). It is important to note here that significance, in Ogden and Richards' work, simply means "The Place of anything in a system."[17] So, if the speaker in our thought experiment meant that person X simply lived holding a place in a system, then the statement breaks down into a truism, since every life holds a place in some system. Ogden and Richards themselves admit that this sense is "too vague to be of much service even to orators,"[18] and that restrictions are commonly introduced, most notably to a thing's consequences.[19] Yet even narrowed, the definition fails. A tyrant's life has consequences as vast as any saint's, and so, measured by significance alone, a saint's life and a tyrant's life become equally "meaningful." This is likely not the speaker's intended claim, as it is typical of speakers to use meaningful life as an evaluation of a life, not a mechanical fact about its place in the world. Whatever separates the saint from the tyrant is not significance, but the evaluation itself.

Finally, if we test the same statement "Person X lived a meaningful life" under Ogden and Richards' very own emotive framework, definition XI, specifically outlined as "Emotion aroused by anything,"[20] then the issue is resolved. This is because when run through definition XI, the statement functions exactly as the ethical "good" does in the passage analyzed above: it expresses an attitude of approval toward the life, though not necessarily the same attitude that "good" expresses. This introduces no new fictitious entities into our ontology, nor

[15]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 206.
[16]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 186.
[17]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 186.
[18]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 197.
[19]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 198.
[20]Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 186.

does it reduce the word to redundancy or collapse the evaluative claim into a structural truism. It also explains why "meaningful" and "good" come apart. A dictator may call his own life meaningful, and a pleasant, harmless life may be called good without being called meaningful. On the emotive reading this is exactly what we should expect: the two words express different attitudes, approval of a life's comfort or decency in one case and admiration of its weight or consequence in the other, and the dictator's life is "meaningful" to him because the attitude is his. Were "meaningful" a property of the life itself, these cases would be puzzling; as expressions of attitude, they are not. Instead, classifying "a meaningful life" under definition XI acknowledges that the phrase communicates a complex psychological attitude of affirmation and value toward an existence, fulfilling the exact parameters of Ogden and Richards' overarching semantic project.

Though a seemingly minor error by Ogden and Richards, this misclassification matters. Ogden and Richards did not, as previously discussed, label the phrase "meaningful life" as an emotive tool, but rather as a statement trying to pin down a factual reality. Read that way, the phrase reaches toward some larger framework, or cosmic framework, as it is often called, which cannot be tested in a lab, nor empirically verified. It is exactly the kind of claim that A.J. Ayer, whose emotivist treatment of ethics closely parallels Ogden and Richards' analysis of "good," would label a "pseudo-proposition".[21] The intriguing aspect of this inquiry is that if Ogden and Richards had correctly classified the phrase "meaningful life" not as a statement that attempted to make a factual claim, but rather as an expression of validation, then it would never have been subject to Ayer's verification framework at all. Ultimately, this shows that the underlying apparatus for understanding what "a meaningful life" does and does not say was present the entire time, forgotten as a simple misclassification by Ogden and Richards in 1923.

While the above proposition is convincing in principle, there are certain objections that must be addressed. Firstly, it is not outlandish to think one might argue that meaningful is not an empty word, but rather a selective word that encompasses what an individual deems worthwhile. For example, meaning, in an individual's sense, selects for raising a family, and against a tyrant's conquests. The issue here is not that this is a crime against language; in fact, Ogden and Richards concede that "no convenient symbolic device is objectionable" so long as we know it is a device.[22] However, the issue is that this selecting is still an emotive process. The word does practical work, while still failing to add concrete substance to a sentence.

Secondly, a popular academic position in the philosophy of meaning in life currently is

[21] Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, chap. 1.

[22] Ogden and Richards, *Meaning of Meaning*, 188.

the amalgam view of meaning as a cluster of real features such as fulfilling purposes, meriting esteem, etc. This position, defended by, among others, Metz and Seachris,[23] is intriguing, but really, just a clever framework for the same underlying issue, even if the proponents of this view are largely right that this is how humans tend to use the word, "meaningful" or "meaning of life". It is important to note as well this paper is largely only concerned with "meaningful" and "meaningfulness," and under this framework "meaning of life" is treated as equivalent to the latter mentioned because all three of these imply an evaluative sense rather than a semantic one, which is what this paper is concerned with. With that being said, we can run the amalgam argument through the same testing framework as above, taking each member of the cluster one at a time. Firstly, if by "meaningful" the speaker means that person X fulfilled their purposes, then we are simply back at definition VII; person X raised three children, built a business, or kept a promise, and these are real and can be checked, but "meaningful" adds nothing to them. Secondly, if the speaker means that person X's life merited esteem, then the claim is essentially an evaluation, and "merited esteem" makes no more difference to our reference than "good" does; it falls under definition XI as an emotive statement. Either way, the amalgam view is effective in clearing up what humans intend by "meaningful," but it still fails to add concrete substance: the cluster is simply redundant facts bundled together with an attitude, and nothing remains once both are taken away.

The third objection, and this is the same objection people raised against logical positivism, is that if this system concerning "meaningful life" is true, then there is literally no point to discuss and debate if a life was meaningful. This objection is essentially correct to a point but must be qualified. People can still disagree about facts under this framework; they just cannot settle disagreements about emotive statements. Ayer deals with this by essentially holding that when people disagree, it is fundamentally linked back to the facts of the situation; they might say they disagree on if person X was loving, but they won't just repeat that line verbatim; they will instead offer concrete facts such as: "well, he hugged his daughter every night before bed" to prove that person X was loving.[24] So this objection is largely a moot point, as people are able to disagree about the characteristics of one's life, simply not the "meaning" of it.

Finally, some may argue this argument is self-refuting, as it uses meaning to seemingly justify that meaning is an empty linguistic convenience. Perhaps, but that is not what this argument holds. In fact, this paper only holds meaning, in reference to a meaningful life, or the meaning of life, as a failed proposition, and instead meaning as a whole can fit well

[23]Thaddeus Metz, "The Meaning of Life," in *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/life-meaning.

[24]Ayer, *Language, Truth and Logic*, chap. 6.

underneath Ogden and Richards' definition XIII (suggestion). Meaning may certainly suggest; it simply may not suggest objective evaluative claims about a suggestion (meaningful) applied to a physical entity (life).

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